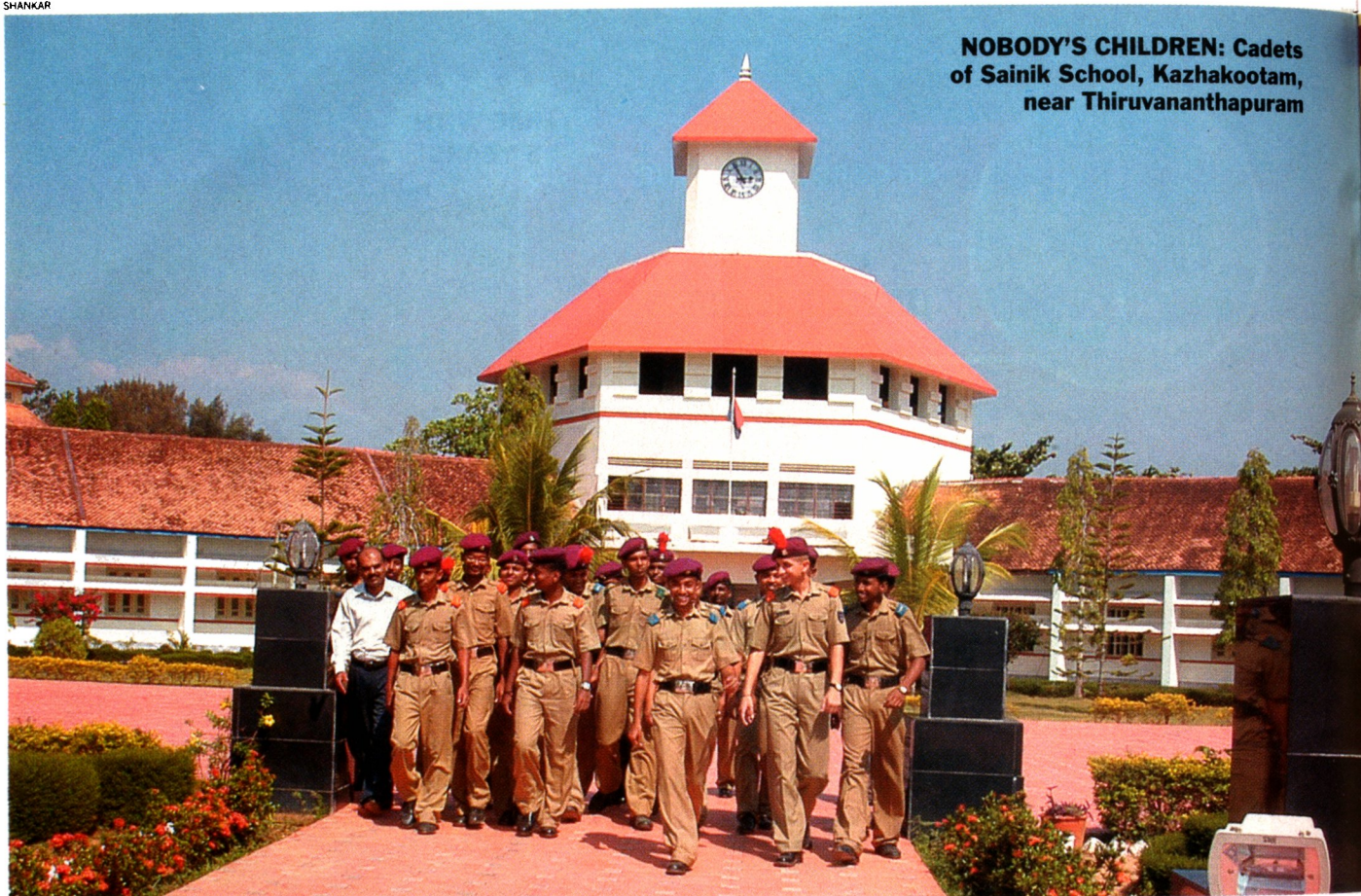


SHANKAR



NOBODY'S CHILDREN: Cadets of Sainik School, Kazhakootam, near Thiruvananthapuram

SCHOOLS OF NEGLECT

The Centre doles out Rs 44 crore for Sainik Schools as it hunts for defence officers but has not addressed the main issue of ownership and inadequate support from the states

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

Dangerous zone. Building declared unsafe. Keep five metres away. Do not enter the building", the red signboard, in a corridor encircled by giant cracks, warns people. This dilapidated building houses Sainik School, Balachadi. Located 35 km from Jamnagar in Gujarat, in a zone of poor cellular coverage, it was one of the first five military schools established by the Ministry of Defence (MOD) over 40 years ago to train students for the prestigious National Defence Academy (NDA), but its students would be lucky if they walk out alive.

Funding and infrastructure for these schools is provided by state governments but administrative personnel, comprising officials of the three

armed forces, are provided by the MOD. With declining interest from the states—the Gujarat government is one of the nine the Ministry charges with not providing enough budgetary support—the schools are falling apart. This decline comes at a time when the armed forces find it increasingly difficult to attract and retain talent.

It is a concern that found expression in Finance Minister P. Chidambaram's latest Budget speech. "I am concerned by the rate of attrition in the defence forces, especially at the officer level. Sainik Schools have played a unique

role as a recruiting and training ground of future leaders of the defence forces..." Chidambaram said, announcing a one-time grant of Rs 44 crore for the schools. Yet, the Centre's first-ever budgetary allocation may not be enough to fix a story of neglect and lack of accountability.

The schools were to act as primary feeder institutions for the NDA, throw open the doors of the military's officer elite to those from humbler backgrounds, redress regional imbalances in the army and bring public school education within the reach of the com-



"Budgetary support from the state governments is inadequate"

M.M. PALLAM RAJU, MINISTER OF STATE FOR DEFENCE